

‘Every little thing we do should exude luxury’

Puneet Chhatwal, MD & CEO of The Indian Hotels Company Limited, explains what luxury means for the Taj group of hotels, the importance of heritage, and why one can never quantify something like luxury

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PHOTO BY **MILIND SHELTE**

92 |

IN THE OPULENT yet tastefully done-up Rajput Suite of the iconic Taj Mahal Palace in Mumbai, Puneet Chhatwal, 58, is all smiles. Business is looking up and—by his own admission—it has been “quite an experience” as MD & CEO of The Indian Hotels Company (IHCL). With properties (and brands) spread across the globe, Chhatwal has his hands full. The topic of luxury is close to his heart, and how to marry it with a robust business proposition is one of the things that keeps him busy. Edited excerpts from an interview:

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What does the concept of luxury mean to you?

Luxury is something that is special—you feel it, cherish it and respect it, and it only keeps evolving with time. The formula that worked yesterday in luxury is not a successful recipe for tomorrow. Luxury brands are timeless. There are a few things that make them unique. For instance, they don’t follow fads in the short term. They have a holistic perspective about everything... One cannot adopt a cookie-cutter approach to luxury.

Luxury has evolved in a good way. With time, the pricing goes up and its consumption is crisis-resistant. It is hard to define luxury but one needs to understand the various attributes that come to be associated with it. When it comes to luxury, trust is earned over time, and one has to sustain that trust and continuously reinforce it. A luxury brand has

to be resilient, stylish and always be a step ahead of what other brands normally stand for. Only then will it manage to stand the test of time.

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Tell us how it works for your brands...

In every category, we should be perceived as premium, and that encompasses everything including Qmin, our signature food delivery [service]. Of course, it is important to be profitable as well. If you are a premium offering, people will pay for it... Look at Ginger, which is lean luxury, or Vivanta—within upscale, it is the most premium. There is the Taj and within that, we should be among the top 10-20 luxury brands across the world. Our approach is that every little thing we do should exude luxury.

Take the Lake Palace in Udaipur or the Umaid Bhawan in Jodhpur or The Pierre in New York overlooking Central Park. They were and continue to be leaders. Again, look at the Taj Bengal in Kolkata or the Taj Krishna in Hyderabad—we are simply blessed with the most iconic assets.

We have undergone an important exercise over the last five years. During this time, 17 assets have been upgraded to the Taj. It was a very good decision to take. In luxury, one needs to continuously re-invent and re-invest to stay relevant while standing out. The competitive advantage comes from your ability to define a premium and the cost of delivery... We are blessed with our forefathers having given